



CREATING A PROBLEM STATEMENT

a Modular workshop



Introduction

This workshop supports you in finding a relevant problem which you, together with the respective community, can solve. Please approach this workshop as an exercise for yourself to become more familiar with creating a well defined problem statement.

Keep in mind: What you write down in this form does not have to be related to your Limitless project!

Multiple exercises will help you to gradually build to an outcome of a problem statement which is clear and realisable. The first part (this document) consists of 6 pages with small exercises which gradually help you to build a good problem statement.

It is recommended to work chronologically through the pages, but you can always switch between pages and go back.



These six pages, respectively: formulating your dream, from dream to problem, problem tree, problem framing, stakeholder identification and reframing your problem statement, are going to help you to gather a good understanding of the problem in a community and the people involved.

Please fill out this PDF, by clicking on the blank spaces adding your answer. After filling out the pages, please save the document and send it back to me: **kmerkx@redcross.nl**

At the end of the document you can find an example version, for inspiration and guidance.



When you formulate your dream it is important to try to let go of all the obstacles you face in your daily life. In this exercise you have no limits! Try to think about what you want the most.

1

Formulate your dream

This is where it all starts!

Step 1. Who do you want to help?

Explain who you want to help with your dream. Yourself? People in your community? Children? Try to be specific.



Step 2. What do you want to change?

Explain what it is you would like to see changing for the people you want to help. Try to explain it in detail.



Step 3. Visualise your dream

Look for a picture on the internet (or draw it yourself!) which describes/illustrates/inspires your dream and past it in these squares.



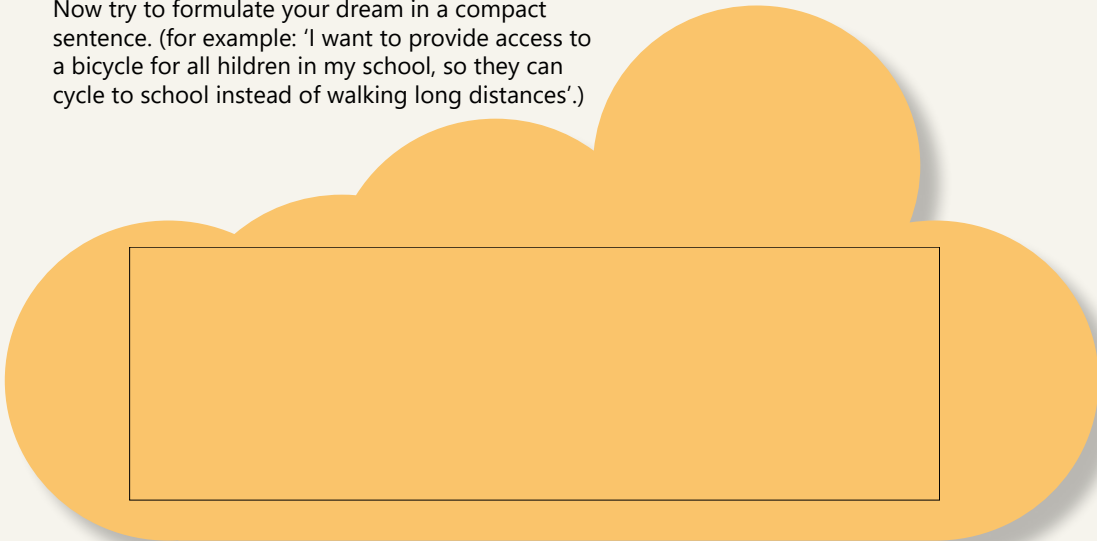
Step 4. What does this mean?

Explain how these pictures describe/illustrate/inspire your dreams.



Step 5. Formulate your dream!

Now try to formulate your dream in a compact sentence. (for example: 'I want to provide access to a bicycle for all children in my school, so they can cycle to school instead of walking long distances'.)




2

From dream to problem

What is preventing you from making your dream reality?



Now you formulated your dream, try to find out what is stopping you from realising this dream and formulate this into a problem statement.



I want to solve...

A

for...

B

because...

C

3

Create a Problem Tree

A problem tree is a method to create an overview of the causes which lead to a certain problem, what this problem is and what the consequences for the community are. Start by defining the causes, set the problem (and think about your ability to solve this problem) and explore what the consequences are for your community.



Step 3 What are the consequences for the community?

Be creative and (visually) explain what impacts the community and how. Afterwards, reflect on the impact of these consequences (positive or negative?).



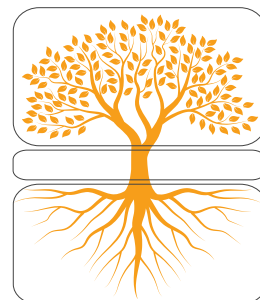
Step 1. Define what is the main problem

Copy what you have written in box A on the previous page on this place.



Step 2. What causes are preventing you from realising your dream?

Write down all the causes which are hindering from realising our dream at this moment. Add pictures and/or illustrations.



3. Branches
Consequences

1. Trunk
Main problem

2. Roots
Consequences



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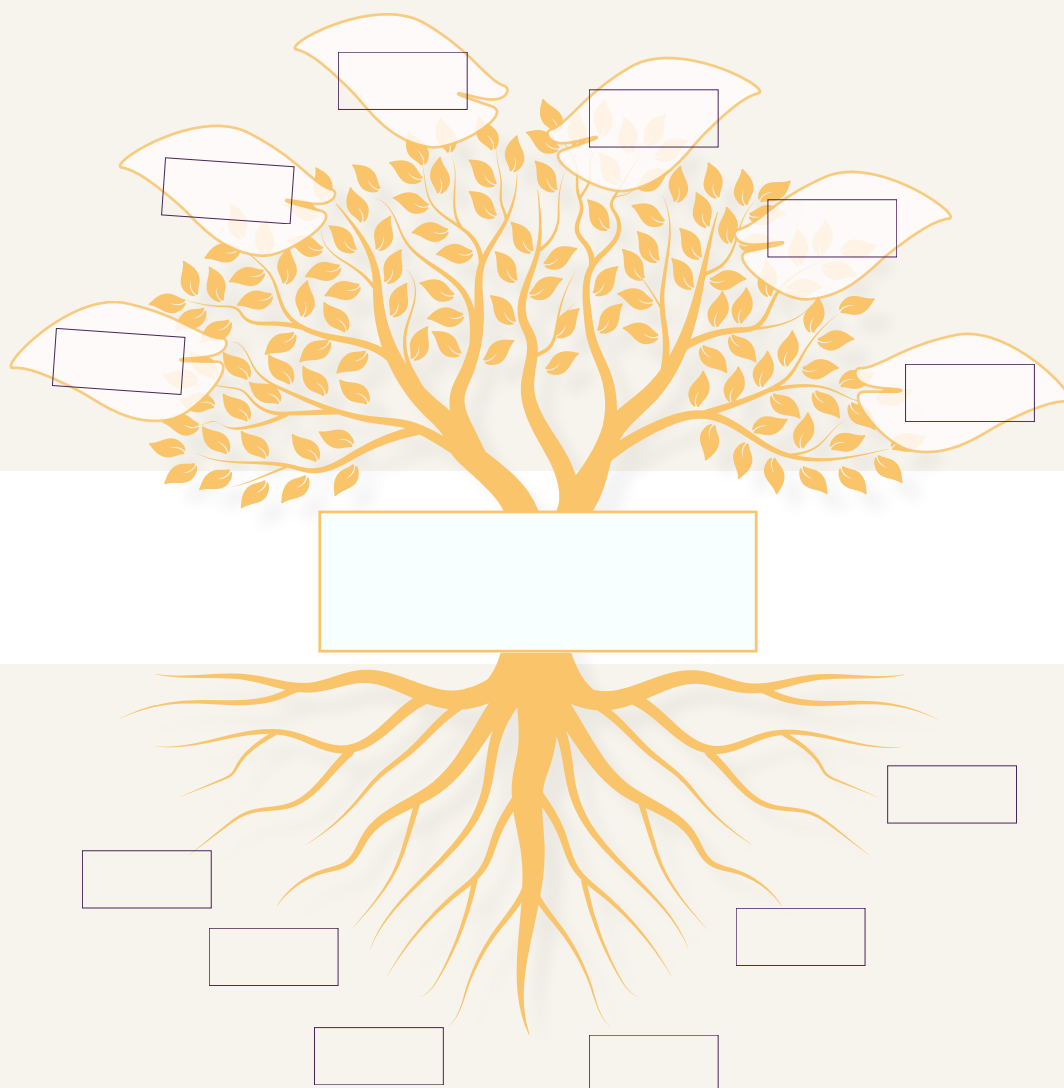
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Start with formulating your problem statement by filling out the blanks.



You want to have a clear objective for your innovation journey. That is why you should start with a well defined problem statement. In order to do so, you are going to reframe your initial problem statement (page 2). Use the reframing questions to critically review your problem statement and write down the reframed version here.

Reframing questions

- Is it true?
- Did you include an explanation?
- Did you include a solution?
- Did you limit potential solutions?
- Is it clear?
- Whose problem is it?
- Are there strong emotions?
- Are there false trade-offs?



I want to solve...

A

for...

B

because...

C

Stakeholder identification

Map out all the stakeholders which are involved in this problem space.



Identifying stakeholders and the problem owner is important to create an overview of the parties which are involved in your problem. To create a better understanding of their perspective, you are going to reach out to all the stakeholders and together do some exercise. But first, let's find the stakeholders who are involved!

Stakeholder options



A Government



B Academic parties



C Companies



D Profit / not profit

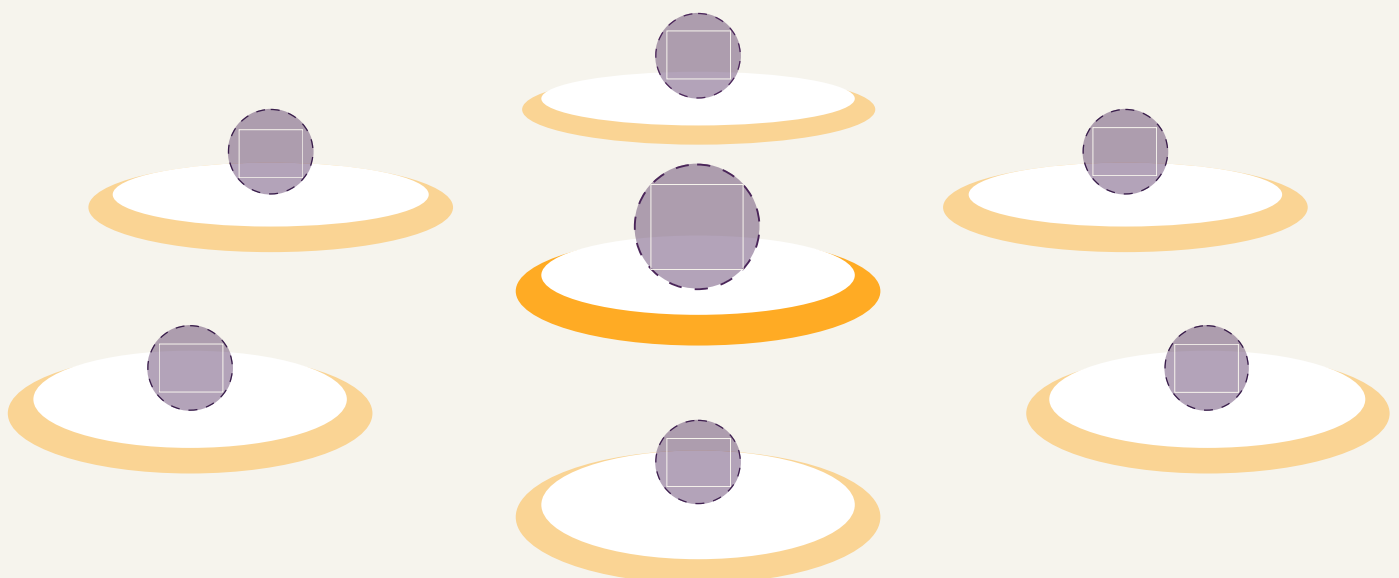


E Community



F Others

Copy the letter of the stakeholders in the stakeholder map, or add other stakeholders which you think are relevant.



Continue to improve your problem statement



After mapping your stakeholders it is important to take a second look at your problem statement. How do all these stakeholder influence your problem statement? Can it be more clear or made more specific? Copy your last version (page 4) and see how it can be improved!

Reframing questions

- Is it true?
- Did you include an explanation?
- Did you include a solution?
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I want to solve...

A

for...

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C

Example pages

The following pages provide an example of how to fill out this workshop template. It can be used as inspiration.



When you formulate your dream it is important to try to let go of all the obstacles you face in your daily life. In this exercise you have no limits! Try to think about what you want the most.

1

Formulate your dream

This is where it all starts!

Step 1. Who do you want to help?

Explain who you want to help with your dream. Yourself? People in your community? Children? Try to be specific.

All the young boys and girls in my community in elementary school

Step 3. Visualise your dream

Describes what inspires your dream

I can imagine young children using a bicycle to get to school, together with a group of friend from the community.

Step 2. What do you want to change?

Explain what it is you would like to see changing for the people you want to help. Try to explain it in detail.

I hope they don't have to walk to school anymore.

Step 4. What does this mean?

Explain how these pictures describe/illustrate/inspire your dreams.

Children will get quicker to their schools, making the trip less dangerous and leaves them with more time to do other things.

Step 5. Formulate your dream!

Now try to formulate your dream in a compact sentence. (for example: 'I want to provide access to a bicycle for all children in my school, so they can cycle to school instead of walking long distances'.)

'I want to provide access to a bicycle for all children in my school, so they can cycle to school instead of walking long distances'

2

From dream to problem

What is preventing you from making your dream reality?



Now you formulated your dream, try to find out what is stopping you from realising this dream and formulate this into a problem statement.



I want to solve...

children in my community don't have a bike to go to school

A

for...

for young children in my community

B

because...

currently going to school takes a lot of time and the road to school can be dangerous.

C

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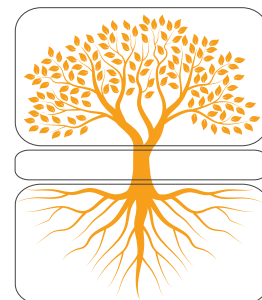
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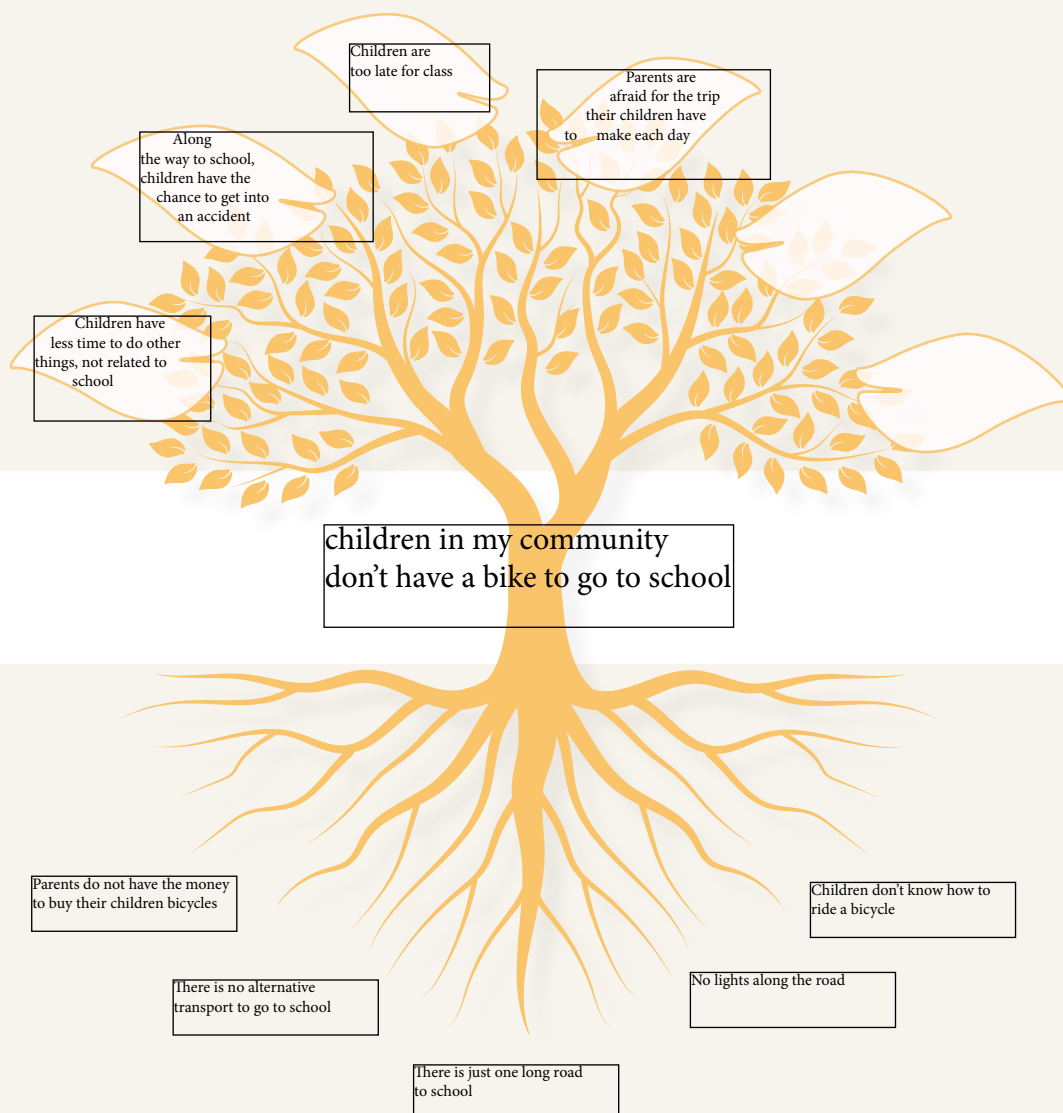
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- Whose problem is it?
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- Are there false trade-offs?



I want to solve...

the potential dangers during the long commute to school

A

for...

for young children in my community

B

because...

currently they spend a lot of time traveling to school and back to the community by foot, which causes potential dangers.

C

Stakeholder identification

Map out all the stakeholders which are involved in this problem space.



Identifying stakeholders and the problem owner is important to create an overview of the parties which are involved in your problem. To create a better understanding of their perspective, you are going to reach out to all the stakeholders and together do some exercise. But first, let's find the stakeholders who are involved!

Stakeholder options



A Government



B Academic parties



C Companies



D Profit / not profit



E Community



F Others

Copy the letter of the stakeholders in the stakeholder map, or add other stakeholders which you think are relevant.

Government - providing alternative transport for the students



Academic partner - the schools of the children



Government - providing safer routes for the children



The parents of the young children



The children



Community - Adults in the community can help the young students

Companies - sponsoring resources for the community (bicycles for example)





After mapping your stakeholders it is important to take a second look at your problem statement. How do all these stakeholder influence your problem statement? Can it be more clear or made more specific? Copy your last version (page 4) and see how it can be improved!

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- Is it clear?
- Whose problem is it?
- Are there strong emotions?
- Are there false trade-offs?



I want to solve...

the potential dangers during the long commute to school and back to the community

A

for...

for young children in my community, between 6 and 12 years old

B

because...

currently they spend a lot of time traveling to school and back to the community by foot, which causes potential dangers.

C